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August 27, 2025

Ms. Krista Mason
Principal Planner
County of Riverside - Lead/Public Agency
4080 Lemon Street, 12th Floor
Riverside, CA 92501

CC Via E-Mail: kmason@rivco.org

Re: **Comments for the Initial Study/Mitigated Negative Declaration (IS/MND) for Conditional Use Permit No. 230002: Crescent Gardens Cemetery**

Dear Ms. Mason,
As a twenty-five-year drinking water professional, public health advocate, and the elected Director of Elsinore Valley Municipal Water District, representing Division One where the proposed project will be located. I also serve on the United States Environmental Protection Agency Local Government Advisory Committee where I co-chair the Water Committee. Based on my experience and expertise, I am submitting the following comments regarding the Crescent Gardens Cemetery:

The project is located within the San Jacinto Watershed, which drains into Railroad Canyon Reservoir, also known as Canyon Lake. Home to more than 11,000 residents, Canyon Lake is one of only three surface water reservoirs in the state of California that allows body contact, and in addition to local groundwater, is a key drinking water source.

Since the initial authorization of the Safe Drinking Water Act in 1974 and the subsequent 1996 amendments, Source Water Protection has taken a prominent role. States followed the lead and developed their own regulatory statutes to protect drinking water sources and ensure public health. In California there is a **regulatory obligation** under California Code of Regulations Title 22 and federally, in the Safe Drinking Water Act 1996 Amendments to protect public health by **safeguarding source water from actual and potential contamination sources**.

The Federal 1996 Safe Drinking Water Act Amendments require states and systems to assess susceptibility of drinking water to contamination, including land uses within watersheds. **It also allows communities to petition for regulatory intervention when new projects threaten drinking water supplies**. To further complicate this situation, Canyon Lake allows full body contact; there is no available remedy or mitigation known to protect families, children, and infants from direct contamination and acute public health risk (Please see attached table for Key Contaminants from Human Decomposition and Related Impacts on Drinking Water) that the proposed Crescent Gardens Cemetery poses.

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Based on California Code of Regulations Title 22, the Safe Drinking Water Act 1996 Amendments, and the significant public health risk to Canyon Lake residents who recreate in and around the reservoir, the Crescent Gardens Cemetery project poses an unacceptable high risk to drinking water and public health. The CEQA review must classify it as a significant hazard, evaluate cumulative contamination impacts, and require relocation, or denial of the project.

Sincerely,

Darcy M. Burke, M.B.A.
President & C.E.O.

Attachment

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Key Contaminants from Human Decomposition
&
Related Impacts on Drinking Water

Contaminant Category	Specific Substances	Source in Decomposition	Potential Impact on Drinking Water
Nitrogen Compounds	Ammonia, Nitrate, Nitrite	Protein breakdown	Nitrate contamination; exceeds Title 22 MCL (10 mg/L as N)
Phosphorus Compounds	Orthophosphate	Cell membrane breakdown	Reservoir eutrophication, harmful algal blooms
Volatile Fatty Acids	Butyric acid, propionic acid	Anaerobic breakdown	Odor/taste issues, high oxygen demand
Biogenic Amines	Cadaverine, Putrescine	Protein/amino acid breakdown	Toxic at high levels; odor; taste issues
Sulfur Compounds	Hydrogen sulfide, mercaptans	Sulfur amino acid breakdown	Corrosivity, odor, toxicity
Phenolic Compounds	Phenols, cresols	Tissue degradation	Persistent organics; toxicity
Pathogens (Bacteria)	E. coli, Salmonella, Clostridium	Gastrointestinal flora	Fecal contamination, acute illness
Pathogens (Viruses)	Enteroviruses, Adenoviruses, Norovirus	Human remains	Persistence in groundwater; infectious at low dose
Pathogens (Protozoa)	Cryptosporidium, Giardia	Intestinal protozoa	Chlorine-resistant, significant reservoir risk